Letting his frustration known that he was not able to convince the higher ups, Dhar flaunts his ignorance by implying that rockets can be duplicated using stolen and smuggled drawings thus, '… Pakistan had abiding interest in Indian rocket technology and they were themselves engaged in developing indigenous rockets with borrowed and stolen know-how.'

Those who agree with Dhar should know that if this is true, Pakistan could source these drawings from many small-scale industries, which are given the drawings of several components for fabrication. And then, there is a difference between know-how and know-why, the latter being the reason we worked in close coordination with the French for almost five years to develop the Vikas engine. If a bunch of drawings were enough, we need not have gone to Vernon to master it.

Here is an extract from the open letter signed by the country's leading scientists and administrators in space science: 'As people who have been associated with technology development in India, we have not been able to understand the logic of what is supposed to have happened in the "espionage case". Clearly the acquisition of technology by any foreign power is quite a complex process. Experience indicates that even when drawings are acquired under open technology transfer agreements, their transformation into working hardware takes time, expertise and large financial outlays.

'The Maldivian women involved, their mode of entry into India or their activities seem to be inconsistent with the aim of acquiring sensitive technology by any interested foreign power. ISRO does not classify working level documents as secret, top secret or confidential. An internal investigation carried out by ISRO has shown that there are no original drawings related to the Viking or cryogenic engines missing. In fact, in this case, even fabrication drawings which ISRO routinely passes on to industry, are not missing.'

Dhar's observations on rocketry and 'the plot' show either he was ignorant of how rocket technology is transferred or if he had some basic